

THE CONDITIONAL CLAUSE

Study these sentences:

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| I | If you go there tonight, you will meet Tom. |
| II | If you went there tonight, you would meet Tom. |
| III | If you had gone there yesterday, you would have met Tom. |

Try to translate the sentences into your own language. They represent different kinds of **conditions**.

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| I | Possible condition - the condition is quite real and possible and is quite likely to come true. |
| II | Less likely but possible condition - the condition is more unlikely to materialise but still might possibly happen. |
| III | Impossible condition - this condition is no longer a realistic option - the time for it has passed by and it can not materialise. |

Study the sentences again:

- | | |
|-----|--|
| I | If you go there tonight, you will meet Tom. |
| II | If you went there tonight, you would meet Tom. |
| III | If you had gone there yesterday, you would have met Tom. |

NOTE!!!

The above sentences are a combination of:

- a main clause : you **will meet** Tom
- a conditional sub clause: if you **go** there tonight
- the main clause contains an auxiliary verb: **will** or **would** + main verb.
- the conditional clause contains a simple tense form of the verb: **go**.

USE OF TENSE FORMS AND AUXILIARY VERBS

The use of Tense forms and auxiliary verbs follow a very regular pattern in main clause - if clause combinations:

- I If you **go** there tonight, you **will meet** Tom.
if -clause Simple Present, main clause the auxiliary will.
- II If you **went** there tonight, you **would meet** Tom.
if -clause Past Tense, main clause the auxiliary would
- III If you **had gone** there yesterday, you **would have met** Tom.
if -clause Past Perfect Tense , main clause the auxiliary would + have + Past Participle of main verb, i.e. -ed form of regular verbs, or III form of irregular verbs

NOTE! Other auxiliaries may be used to express the conditions.

Study the following sentences:

- I If you listen to the radio, you **can** improve your knowledge.
If you go there tonight, you **may** meet Tom. (**it is uncertain**)
If you go there tonight, you **might** meet Tom. (**it is even more uncertain**)
- II If Tom were here he **might/could** help us.
If you listened to the radio, you **could/might** improve your knowledge.
If you went there tonight you **might** meet Tom.
- III If Tom had been here he **would/could/might** have helped us.